

**BEFORE THE PUBLIC UTILITIES COMMISSION
OF THE STATE OF CALIFORNIA**

Order Instituting Rulemaking to
Modernize the Electric Grid for a High
Distributed Energy Resources Future.

Rulemaking 21-06-017
(Filed June 24, 2021)

**COMMENTS OF THE VEHICLE-GRID INTEGRATION COUNCIL ON THE HIGH
DER STAFF PROPOSAL**

Zach Woogen
Interim Executive Director
VEHICLE-GRID INTEGRATION COUNCIL
10265 Rockingham Dr.
Suite#100-4061
Sacramento, California 95827
Telephone: (510) 665-7811
Email: vgicregulatory@vgicouncil.org

Date: May 28, 2024

**BEFORE THE PUBLIC UTILITIES COMMISSION
OF THE STATE OF CALIFORNIA**

Order Instituting Rulemaking to
Modernize the Electric Grid for a High
Distributed Energy Resources Future.

Rulemaking 21-06-017
(Filed June 24, 2021)

**COMMENTS OF THE VEHICLE-GRID INTEGRATION COUNCIL ON THE HIGH
DER STAFF PROPOSAL**

In accordance with the Rules of Practice and Procedure of the California Public Utilities Commission (“Commission”), the Vehicle-Grid Integration Council (“VGIC”) hereby submits these comments on the *Administrative Law Judges’ Ruling Seeking Comment on the Staff Proposal* (“Ruling”) and *Administrative Law Judges’ Ruling Memorializing Extension of Time to File Comments and Providing Corrected Staff Proposal* issued by Administrative Law Judges (“ALJ”) Kelly A. Hymes and Manisha Lakhanpal on March 13, 2024 and April 5, 2024, respectively.

I. INTRODUCTION.

VGIC appreciates Energy Division Staff’s work to create a comprehensive Staff Proposal on changes to the investor-owned utilities (“IOUs”) distribution planning processes (“DPP”) and project execution process. The Staff Proposal addresses many improvements that need to be made to allow for the integration of large amounts of distributed energy resources (“DERs”) that will add load and generation capacity to California. This state is facing large amounts of DER integration and interconnection in a very short period of time, seriously challenging the existing distribution planning process that has had to accommodate relatively small and longer lead time load growth. Overall, VGIC supports many of the recommendations made by the Staff Proposal, including improving the IOUs mid- and long-term load forecasting and distribution planning,

taking a more proactive approach to executing large distribution upgrades, and ensuring that distribution planning and project execution teams are adequately resourced and funded.

At the same time, nearer-term approaches and improvements can be made to help integrate and energize more DERs while longer-term forecasts are improved. To this end, VGIC offers the following comments on the Staff Proposal:

- The Staff Proposal provides further evidence that the Commission should standardize flexible service connections and adopt Limited Load Profiles (“LLPs”).
- Coordination between this proceeding and the Energization Rulemaking (R.24-01-018) will continue to be needed.
- A working group should be established to improve Integration Capacity Analysis (“ICA”) maps.

II. THE STAFF PROPOSAL PROVIDES FURTHER EVIDENCE THAT THE COMMISSION SHOULD STANDARDIZE FLEXIBLE SERVICE CONNECTIONS AND ADOPT LIMITED LOAD PROFILES.

VGIC strongly supports Staff’s Key Goal 1 related to delays and long energization timelines, “IOUs to develop strategies, such as temporary DER placement or limits on energy use as bridging solutions for energization requests that require distribution capacity projects.”¹ Staff describes how, “When a customer energization request requires a distribution capacity upgrade, utilities may be able to energize the customer temporarily, until the upgrade is completed, using temporary load flexibility via voluntary load curtailment *for specific limited times* or DER assets such as mobile batteries. [*emphasis added*]”² In order to fully develop the ability for customers to curtail load during specific times of the day or year, VGIC continues to recommend that the

¹ Staff Proposal at 54.

² Ibid.

Commission take up the creation of standardized flexible connection agreements (“FCAs”) and Limited Load Profiles (“LLPs”).

Recently, Enphase submitted a motion in this proceeding to expand the scope to answer the question “Should the investor-owned utilities be ordered to amend their energization rules to allow customers to elect optional flexible connection agreements that use UL 3141-certified power control systems to implement a Limited Load Profile that avoids distribution upgrades, thus enabling rapid and cost-effective project deployment and operations?”³ VGIC, as well as Cal Advocates, Advanced Energy United, California Solar and Storage Association, Clean Coalition, PowerFlex, The Mobility House, and Pacific Gas and Electric (“PG&E”) all expressed support for the motion and encouraged near-term record building on these issues. The Staff Report only provides another piece of evidence that Enphase’s motion should be adopted, as the development of FCAs and LLPs directly implements the key goal outlined in the Staff Proposal.

III. COORDINATION BETWEEN THIS PROCEEDING AND THE ENERGIZATION RULEMAKING (R.24-01-018) WILL CONTINUE TO BE NEEDED.

In comments in the Energization OIR and in responses to the Enphase Motion, parties have discussed whether flexible service connection should be taken up in in this High DER or Energization Rulemakings. The issues that need to be resolved to standardize flexible service connections and implement LLPs are cross cutting and involve issues of technology eligibility and technical requirements (i.e., UL 3141), tariff and rule development, utility operations, customer engagement, and data tools and tracking. Some of these issues, such as customer engagement and data tracking are being discussed in the Energization Rulemaking, while technical requirements

³ *Motion of Enphase Energy, Inc. to Amend Scoping Ruling and Schedule to Address Optional Flexible Connection Agreements and the Underwriters’ Laboratory 3141 Standard for Power Control Systems in Investor-Owned Utilities’ Energization Rules* at 7.

and standards seem to better fit the High DER proceeding. VGIC is agnostic to which proceeding takes up these issues but generally recommends that the Commission find a venue for further discussion quickly. Issues also may inevitably be split across proceedings, which is why VGIC has recommended, and continues to emphasize the need for, cross-proceeding coordination.⁴

IV. A WORKING GROUP SHOULD BE ESTABLISHED TO IMPROVE INTEGRATION CAPACITY ANALYSIS MAPS.

VGIC appreciates Staff's consideration of improvements to the ICA maps and recommendations to improve the use of these tools. VGIC strongly supports Staff's recommendation that the ICA maps add hourly and monthly capacity information to help customers implement a Limited Generation Profile ("LGP"), and we are encouraged that PG&E and SCE are looking to incorporate this functionality in their ICA maps.⁵ With the creation of LLPs, as discussed above, VGIC recommends that similar granular data be made available on the Load ICA to help with the development of LLPs.

However, the Commission needs to provide additional oversight for ICA development and management generally. Fundamentally, the ICAs still suffer from a lack of accuracy and customer confidence, and without improvements to these basic elements, these tools are not usable for significant project planning. Numerous issues have been identified with the ICA map, but these have been largely handled by the Commission in one-off orders to the IOUs for these to be fixed. The IOUs do prepare annual reports on refinements to the ICAs but there are no regular venues to hear updates between these annual cycles or engage with the utilities on the ICAs.

⁴ See *Comments of the Vehicle-Grid Integration Council on Phase I Scoping Memo Issues* submitted in R.24-01-018 on May 3, 2024 at 5.

⁵ Staff Proposal at 116.

VGIC therefore supports the creation of an ongoing working group to discuss needed improvements to the ICA and keep the IOUs accountable in remedying issues. This can provide a venue for developers and other stakeholders to bring real-time inaccuracies and other issues with the maps and dialogue with the IOUs on whether these can be fixed and on what timelines. The ongoing working group should focus on improving ICA maps with the goal of providing more certainty to project developers and customers looking to energize load-only sites and interconnect generation at sites with both new load and generation. The working group could also focus on simplifying the energization and/or interconnection process, rather than creating *additional* formalities or "boxes to check" for project developers. The information these maps provide needs to be made more up-to-date, accurate, and easy to understand, and they need to convey meaningful information for them to be useful. Smaller issues are likely to be resolved with informal coordination between the IOUs and oversight from Energy Division Staff and larger issues can be refined before being brought to more formal regulatory proceedings. Working groups and discussion forums convened by Energy Division have been helpful in other instances. For example, the Rule 21 Interconnection Discussion Forum has provided a way for stakeholders to raise issues with generation interconnection procedures and work through potential solutions. VGIC recommends that a similar approach of having regularly scheduled working group meetings be used for ICA improvements.

V. CONCLUSION.

VGIC appreciates the opportunity to provide this response to the motion. We look forward to further collaboration with the Commission and stakeholders on this initiative.

Respectfully submitted,

/s/ Zach Woogen

Zach Woogen

Interim Executive Director

VEHICLE-GRID INTEGRATION COUNCIL

Date: May 28, 2024